several BJP leaders sought to clarify that Nadda's statement was aimed at regional parties run by political families, there had already been enough red flags for Nitish not to pay heed.

He had to act swiftly. And on two fronts: one, to assess and quell any potential intra-party rebellion; and two, to work out an alternative government, taking the RJD with him. JD(U) sources say Nitish, a man of meticulous strategy, put things in motion quietly right after the Jharkhand MLA arrests in Bengal. "Both Nitish and Rajiv Ranjan individually spoke to the MLAs to assess their mindset. Once it was clear that nobody had fallen for the allurements, Nitish moved in for the kill," says a party leader.

The smoothness with which the other task was accomplished also belied its complexity. Tejashwi had to be on the same page. The two leaders had been at loggerheads since July 2017, when Nitish dumped the mahagathbandhan, but he had been working, presciently enough, on melting the ice all through 2022. On April 22, he had dropped in at an iftar at Rabri Devi's residence, and Tejashwi reciprocated by visiting a JD(U) iftar on April 28—with the warm vibes being demonstrated as the CM walked the RJD scion to his vehicle to see him off. On May 11, the two had a one-on-one meeting at the CM's residence. And in July, when RJD patriarch Lalu Yadav turned critically ill, Nitish visited the ICU of a private hospital and had the state government arrange an air ambulance to shift Lalu to AIIMS, Delhi, where he recovered. Top JD(U) sources admit to other off-the-record meetings with Tejashwi too—including one close to D-Day, on August 5, where all details were discussed.

WIN-WIN FOR RJD

The events have come as an unsolicited blessing for Tejashwi. His party had drawn a blank in the 2019 general election. At the helm of Bihar's single largest party and in power now, he can make serious amends in 2024. The CVoter snap poll on August 9, in fact, found him gaining in the state and in Lok Sabha terms. Being with Nitish can burnish his credentials, building a brand for him independent of that of his father. Anyway, Tejashwi has added several inches to his stature since 2015, when he debuted as a greenhorn deputy CM. Expected to resume that role, he's likely to be very influential in the new set-up—his image bolstered by the unstated expectation that Nitish may eventually pass on the baton to him, if he plays his cards wisely. The new regime has a comfortable majority of 164 in the 243-seat assembly—JD(U) 45, RJD 79, Congress 19, CPI(ML) 12, HAM (Secular) 4, CPI(M) 2, CPI 2, Independent 1.

WHILE ONE SECTION IN THE PARTY IS HAPPY AT GOING SOLO AND AIMING FOR GROWTH, THE BJP WILL BE WATCHING NITISH'S POLICY MOVES CLOSELY

For now, the BJP is calling Nitish's act a betrayal of the 2020 mandate. "That mandate was for PM Modi's leadership. It was his appeal that pulled in voters. Not Nitish. The BJP made him CM keeping Bihar in mind, he has ditched the alliance keeping his own interest in front," says Union minister Giriraj Singh. But the party will be left with just 77 MLAs and may become the solitary one in the opposition. Not the ideal place from which to launch its 2024 campaign. The stakes are very high—with Nitish on its side, the NDA had swept 39 out of Bihar's 40 Lok Sabha seats in 2019. With the RJD's 30 per cent Muslim-Yadav vote linking up with Nitish's cohort of EBCs and Mahadalits, it will trigger unpleasant memories of 2015 for the saffron party, when it was reduced to 53 seats in the assembly. It will be no pushover, though. On its own, the BJP has been going from strength to strength in Bihar: its 2020 tally of 74 (out of 110 contested) meant a much higher success rate and vote percentage (42.56) than the RJD's. Even in 2014, the NDA—without the JD(U)—had bagged 31 seats. That's why some in the BJP call the divorce a blessing in disguise for the long term—they say their cadre now span almost all 40 seats and claim Nitish is no longer the vote-catcher he used to be. "It's time we expanded our base and became atmanirbhar," says a Bihar BJP leader.

But even if the party is downplaying the potential impact of Nitish's exit on 2024, the fact is that it's a big setback. First, it puts a question mark on the BJP's capacity to carry along its partners: in the past eight years, the NDA has lost the PDP, the Akali Dal, the TDP and the Shiv Sena, to name only the big exits. Bihar is also pivotal for reasons beyond mere accumulation of seats—the state can host an alternative politics. The BJP will be watching the state's caste census with caution and trepidation; the first draft is expected by February 2023. The exercise naturally goes in favour of caste-based parties like the RJD-JD(U), but it can also stir up OBC politics across India. Overall, the BJP has been attentive to OBC representation, but its default mode is a 'universal' Hindu vote and thus set against Mandal politics. In Bihar, it was forced to support the caste survey, but it will be wary of the demand going national. It will also be watching how the new regime delivers on opening up government jobs for youth and switching back to the pension system instead of NPS for government employees. Crucially, it will be watching any footsteps Nitish makes out of Bihar—many Opposition leaders see him as a potential unifying candidate to take on Modi in 2024. ■